

China Macro Tracker

Structural measures move up the agenda

Economics China

- ◆ Urbanisation 2.0: a new action plan to provide basic public services based on permanent residence
- ◆ China-EU trade tensions: EU mulls new restrictive measures against China while China indicates potential retaliation
- ◆ Anti-involution campaign to continue with institutional reforms in the pipeline

Livelihood: public services will be provided based on permanent residence

On 25 May, the State Council issued opinions on promoting the provision of basic public services based on permanent residence (gov.cn, 25 May). The key tasks are to strengthen education rights for migrant workers' children, include non-hukou households within the coverage of public rental housing, improve the system for enrolling in social insurance, strengthen basic medical provision, enhance employment assistance, and improve last-resort basic services. Measures will focus on optimising the layout of public facilities based on population mobility trends, allocating scarce service resources via a points-based system, strengthening fiscal transfer payments, and optimising the allocation of urban construction land.

The move marks an essential step towards the "people-centred" new urbanisation model. Unlike previous urbanisation strategies that used to focus on shifting rural labour into cities to support manufacturing and construction, the new model positions urbanisation as a key lever for the government's long-term push to build a strong domestic market and boost the consumption-to-GDP ratio via "investing in people". Strengthening access to public services for urban-based migrant workers and families (c170m people) constitutes an integral element of this strategy. The agenda to expand public service provision aims to reduce migrant workers' precautionary savings and unlock their consumption potential. The government's efforts to shift to structural solutions to support consumption were also reflected in fiscal allocations, with a larger share of general public budget spending directed to livelihood-related areas since the start of the year (chart 4). Meanwhile, if China can successfully grow its domestic market, it is also promising to help improve relations with trading partners through increased imports demand.

Trade: China-EU trade disputes are escalating

China's exports growth and a wider trade surplus with the EU are contributing to heightened trade tensions (chart 5). The European Commission is set to discuss new trade policies concerning China on 29 May, which may lead to new restrictive measures (Bloomberg, 21 May). This follows the decision on 19 May to reduce duty-free steel import quotas by 47% and double the out-of-quota tariff. These actions prompted a stronger pushback from the Chinese side. The MOFCOM noted that China will respond firmly with countermeasures if the EU insists on pushing ahead with discriminatory restrictive measures against China (Xinhua, 21 May).

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While the EU has relied on anti-subsidy and anti-dumping measures to impose tariffs on steel and EVs, recent moves suggest the EU is advancing a broader security agenda, such as revisions to the Cybersecurity Act and the Industrial Accelerator Act. These actions may affect broader Chinese firms, especially in energy related sectors. In 2025, EVs, lithium-ion battery and solar cells together accounted for 8.3% of China's exports to the EU while the region accounted for c40% of these products' exports. As noted by HSBC's Chief Asia Economist Fred Neumann et al., China can weather the impact of US protectionism, but tariff cascades from other trading partners will present a more severe challenge (see [Tariff cascade in action](#), 25 Feb 2025).

That said, we think there is still room for negotiations, given the EU's corporate interests in China and supply-chain efficiency. For instance, the EU Chamber of Commerce in China reported that around 25% of European companies in China are shifting more production processes to China (Xinhua, 3 Feb). China's Commerce Minister Wang Wentao is also expected to visit Brussels in late June for key talks with EU Trade leaders (SCMP, 22 May), which should provide opportunities for both sides to negotiate. Separately, the mid-May US-China summit signalled a constructive tone and China's exports to the US also rose c11% y-o-y in April, suggesting some US orders are returning. Stabilised US-China relations may also help ease EU-China tensions.

Anti-involution campaign: institutional reforms remain a top priority

Premier Li Qiang chaired a State Council executive meeting that reiterated building a unified national market as a core requirement for high-quality development. The meeting called for deeper institutional reforms, with priorities including property-rights protection, market access rules, fair competition enforcement, effective social credit system, and market exit mechanisms (Xinhua, 21 May). The same day, a Qiushi commentary - published in the wake of President Xi's 16 May article urging resources and factors of production to cluster around the real economy - added that "resources can enter" does not mean they are "well allocated". It identified local actions that artificially lower entry costs and distort signals as a key root cause of "involution" and identified local protectionism and market fragmentation as an institutional crux.

We had argued in [China anti-involution push](#) (4 February) that while sector-specific initiatives will likely see more progress in the near term, addressing local interference is one of the most challenging issues in the medium term. Recent policy tones suggest revisions of related laws may be accelerated. The government procurement law (revised) and the tendering and bidding law (revised) were included in the first review when the National People's Congress released its legislative agenda for 2026 (gov.cn, 11 May). The Qiushi article also noted that reform of local performance appraisal will be used to rectify local government behaviours (Qiushi, 21 May).

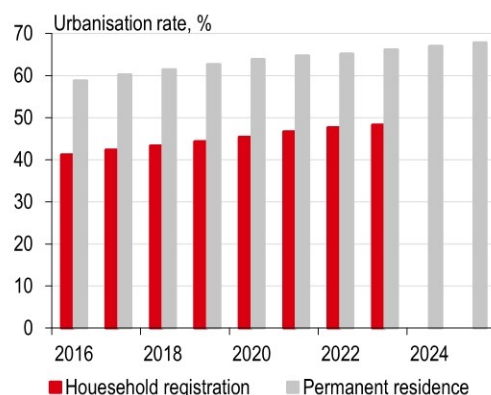
Fiscal data: April pause after a punchy Q1

China's April fiscal data showed a temporary slowdown in spending and echoed the weak investment picture (see [China activity](#), 18 May). The bigger drag came from the government-managed fund, where expenditure fell 21% y-o-y amidst weak land sales (-35% y-o-y) and a temporary slowdown in special local government bond issuance. General public budget expenditure also turned meaningfully weaker despite the improving revenue, which contributed to a narrower deficit of RMB1.1trn (YTD).

We read the temporary slowdown as the government choosing to pause after strong fiscal front-loading and healthy GDP growth in Q1, rather than stepping away from support. Policy reaction will likely depend on whether the recent headwinds prove persistent, with scope for a re-acceleration of bond issuance and deployment of funds should data continue to deteriorate. We expect infrastructure investment to remain a strong growth driver this year, supported by a new policy push for "six networks" (see [China Politburo Meeting](#), 28 April).

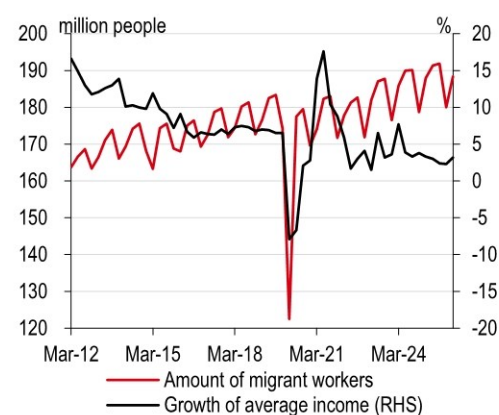
Charts of the week

1. The urbanisation rate of household registration lagged behind that of permanent residence



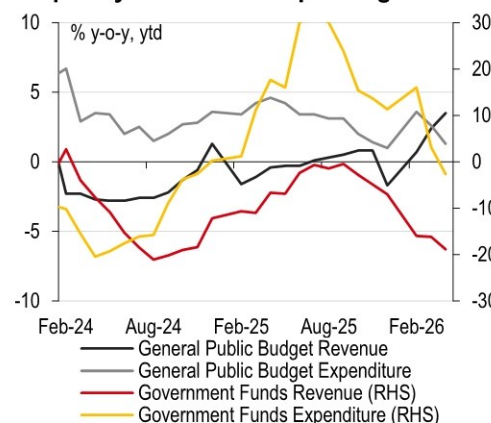
Source: Wind, HSBC

2. Migrant workers' income growth lagged nominal GDP growth



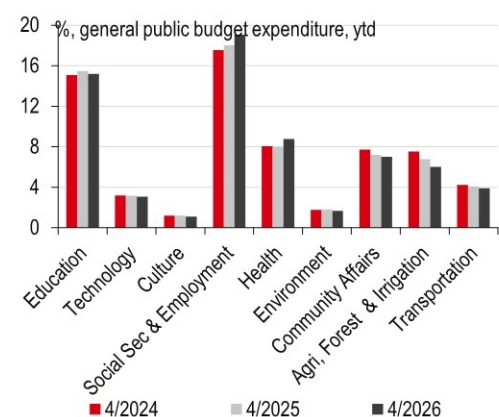
Source: Wind, HSBC

3. China's April fiscal data shows a temporary slowdown in spending



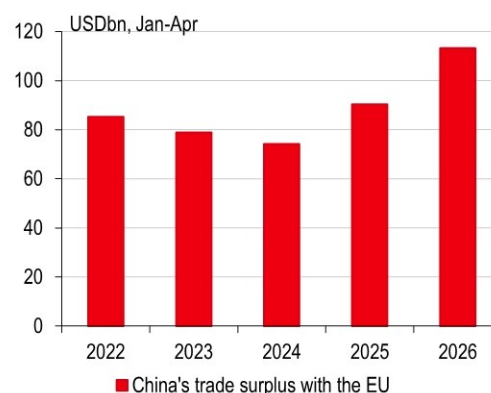
Source: Wind, HSBC

4. More spending was allocated to livelihood-related areas



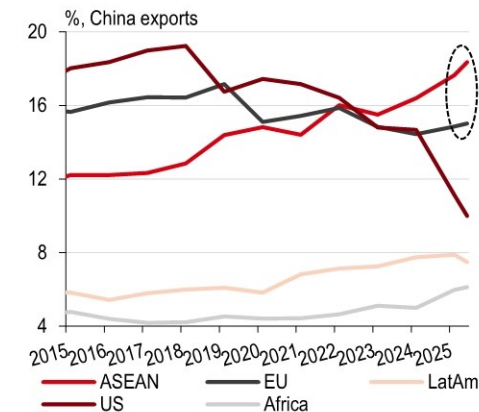
Source: Wind, HSBC

5. China's trade surplus with the EU rose further



Source: Wind, HSBC

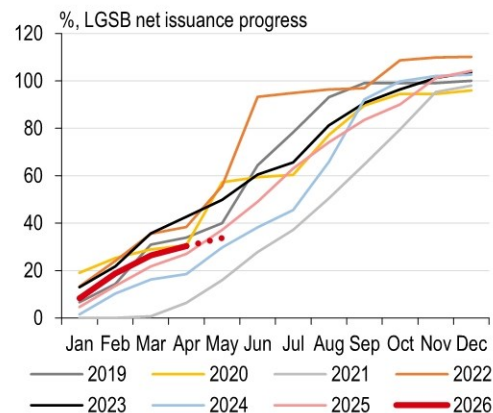
6. Higher exports share to ASEAN and the EU partly offset weaker US demand



Source: Wind, HSBC

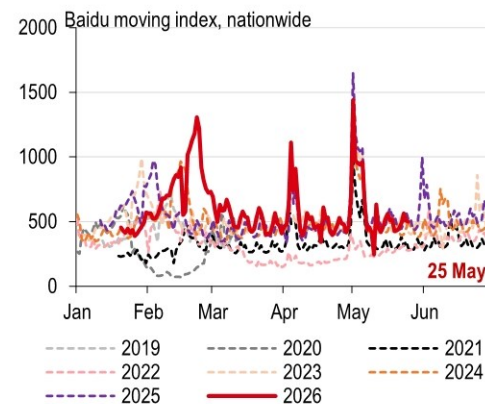
Economic activity

7. LGSB issuance can support a lift in FAI, but issuance pace looks to be moderating



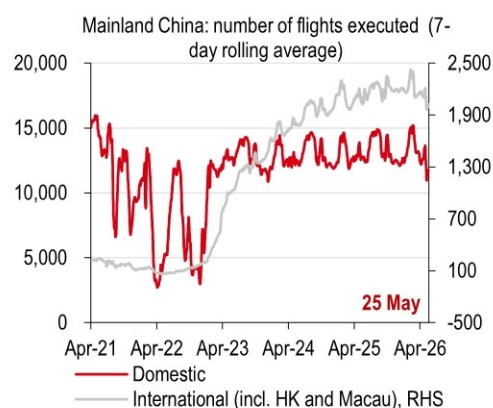
Source: Wind, HSBC; Note: Data as of 26 May.

8. Cross-city travel remained above historical levels



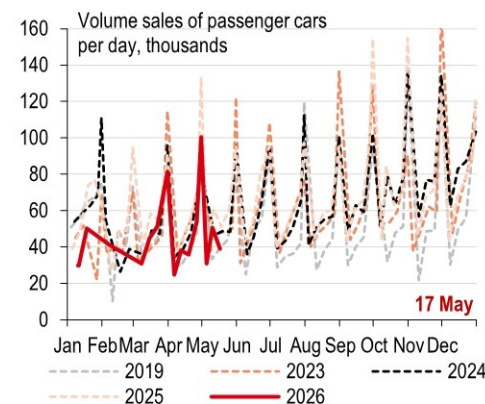
Source: Baidu Index, HSBC

9. The number of domestic flights edged down



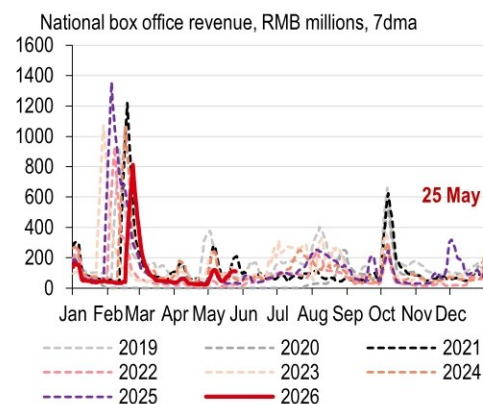
Source: Wind, HSBC

10. Car sales edged down in May



Source: Wind, HSBC

11. National box office revenues edged up

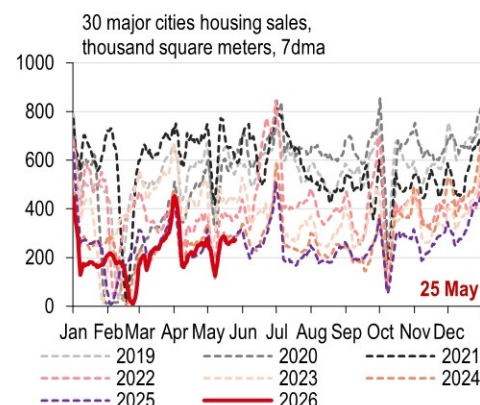
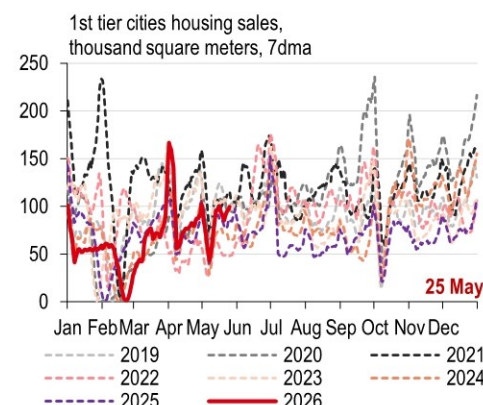


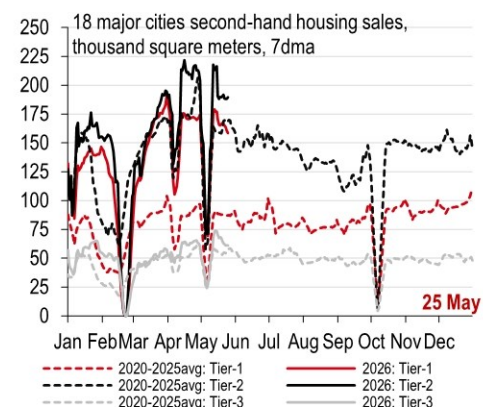
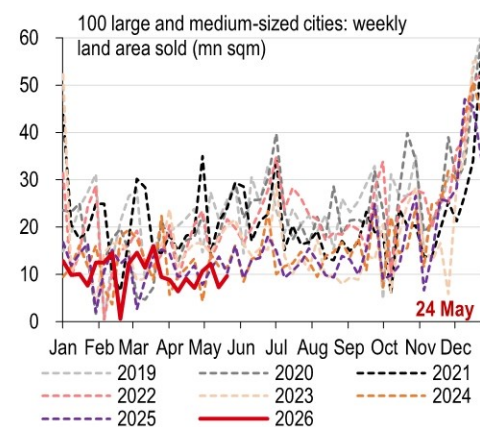
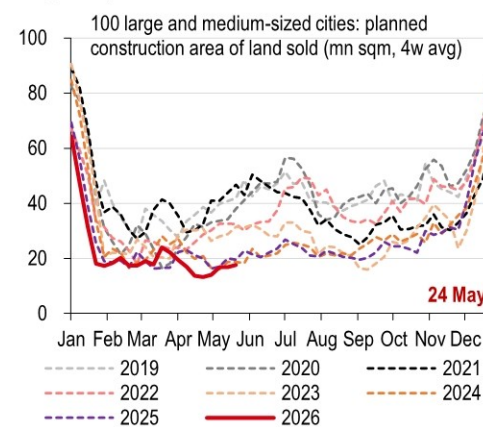
Source: Wind, HSBC

12. Housing prices in tier-1 cities edged up

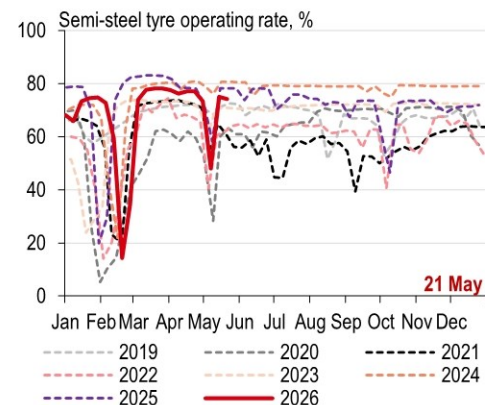


Source: Bloomberg, HSBC; Note: as of 26 May

13. New home sales edged up seasonally

14. New home sales in Tier-1 cities were above last year's levels

15. Second-hand home sales in 18 major cities remained above historical levels

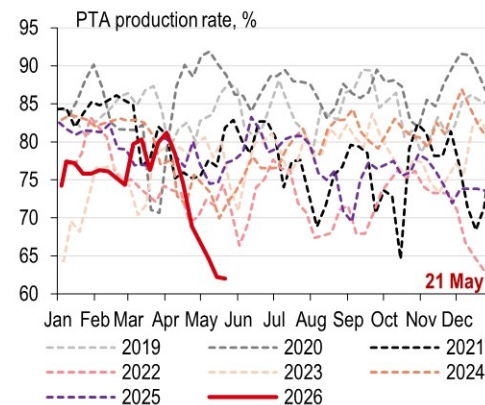
16. Transactions in second-hand homes in Tier-1 & 2 cities remained higher y-o-y

17. Land sales edged up

18. Planned construction area of land sold edged up


19. The semi-steel tyre operating rate edged down



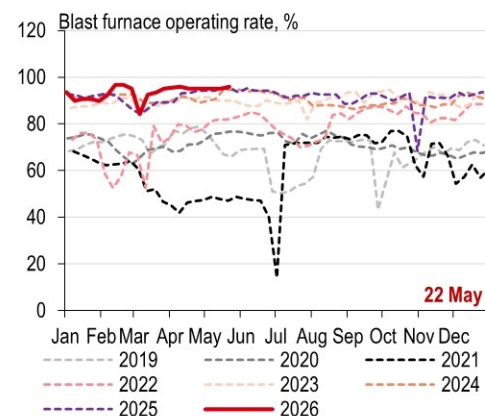
Source: Wind, HSBC

20. The production rate in the chemical sector moved lower



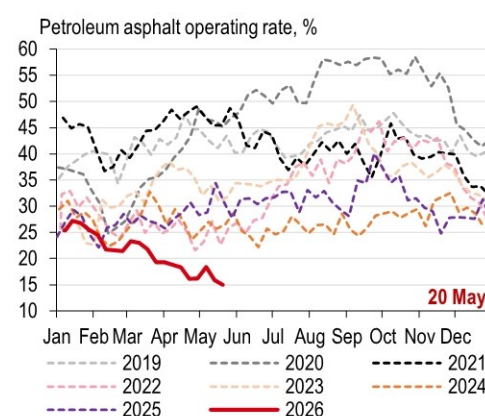
Source: Wind, HSBC

21. The blast furnace operating rate remained above historical levels



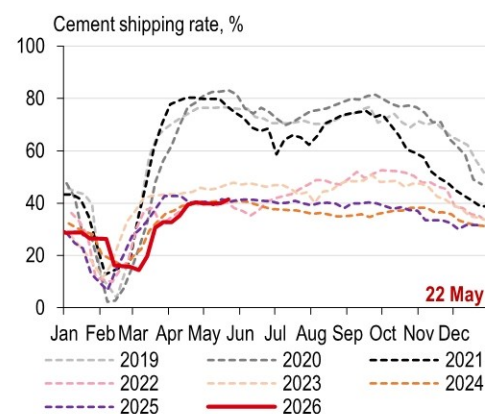
Source: Wind, HSBC

22. The petroleum asphalt operating rate picked moved lower



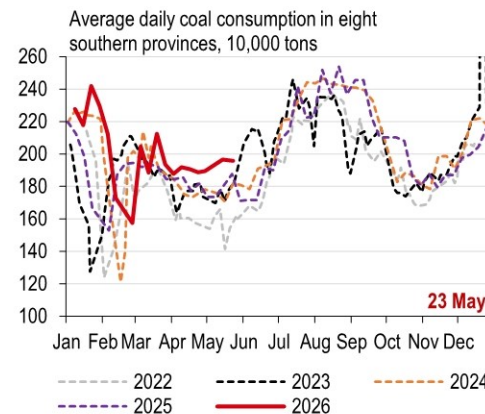
Source: Wind, HSBC

23. The cement shipping rate steadied



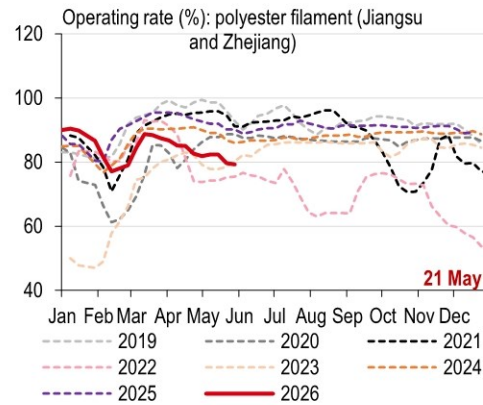
Source: Wind, HSBC

24. Coal consumption for eight major provinces edged down



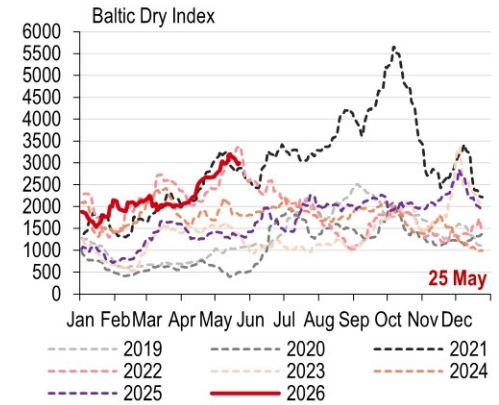
Source: Wind, HSBC

25. The operating rate of polyester filaments eased further



Source: Wind, HSBC

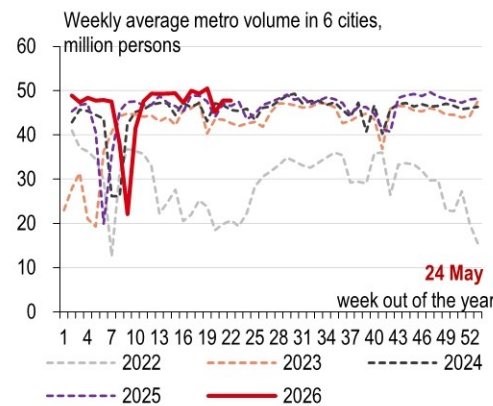
26. The Baltic Dry Index edged down



Source: Wind, HSBC

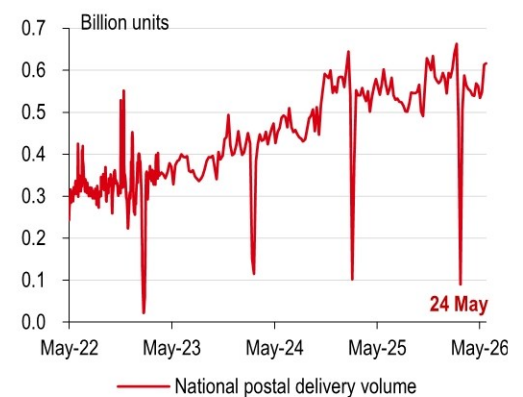
Travel and logistics

27. Metro volumes in large cities edged up seasonally



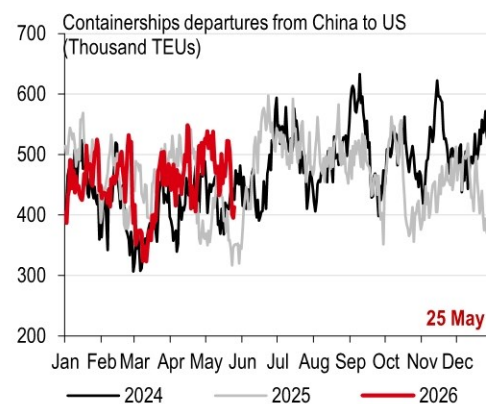
Source: Wind, HSBC; note: six cities include Beijing, Shanghai, Guangzhou, Shenzhen, Chengdu and Tianjin.

28. Postal delivery volumes edged up



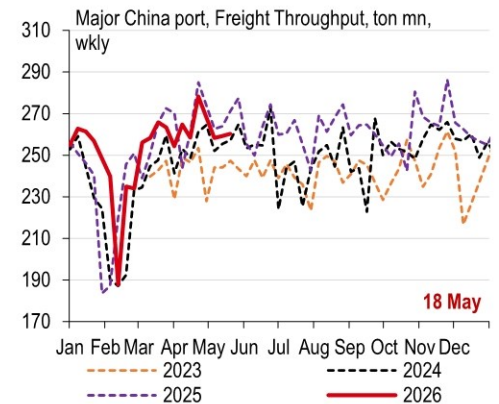
Source: Wind, HSBC

29. Container exports from China to the US edged down



Source: Bloomberg, HSBC

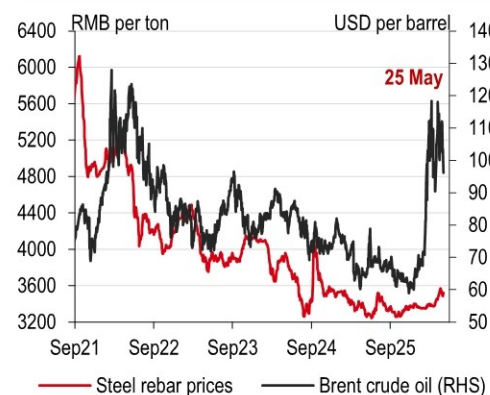
30. China's major ports' freight throughput edged up



Source: CEIC, HSBC; Note: Weekly beginning at Monday

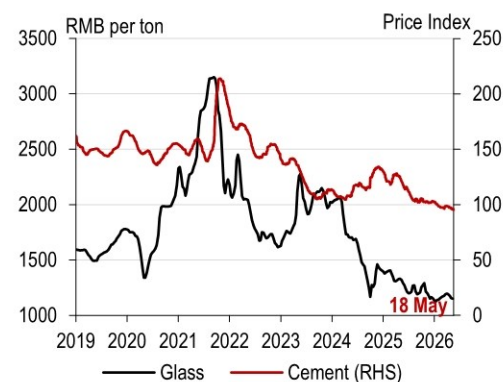
Inflation and policies

31. Crude oil prices moved up again amid ongoing uncertainty in the Middle East



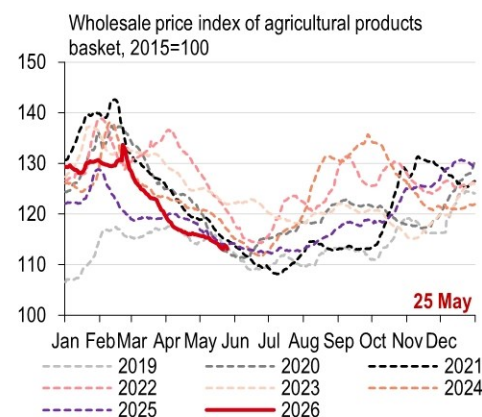
Source: Wind, HSBC

32. Cement prices and glass prices both edged down



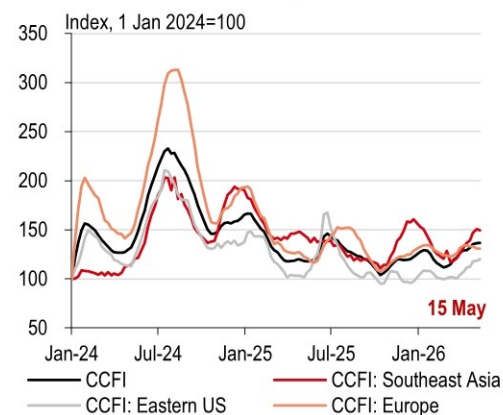
Source: Wind, HSBC

33. Agricultural product prices eased seasonally



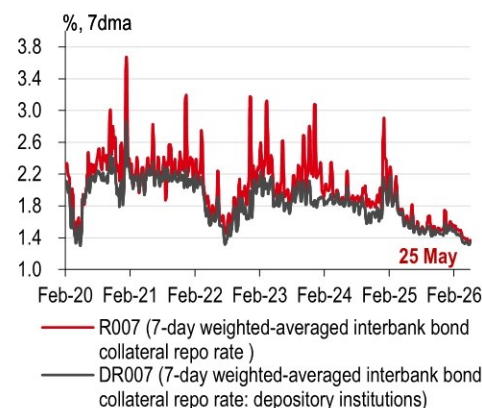
Source: Wind, HSBC

34. Container shipping costs on China-Southeast Asia route edged down



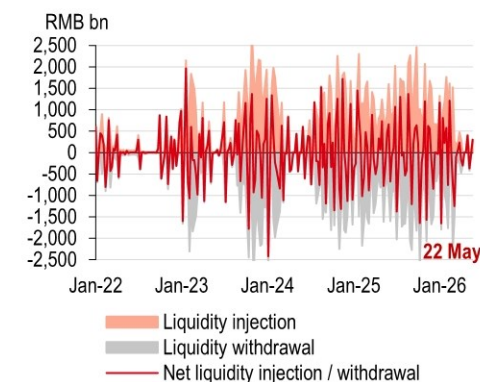
Source: Wind, HSBC

35. Interbank rates edged down



Source: Wind, HSBC

36. The PBoC made net injections through OMOs last week



Source: Wind, HSBC

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